

Philosophy

#4:Epistemology

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EPISTEMOLOGY

Source of Knowing

PRAGMATISM

SCIENTISM

Theory of TRUTH

1. Correspondence Theory of Truth:

It states that a statement, or belief is true if and only if it *corresponds* to, or accurately describes, a fact or state of affairs in the real world. In simpler terms, a statement is true if it matches reality. For example: The statement "The cat is on the mat" is true if and only if there is actually there.

2. **Coherence Theory of Truth:**

This theory posits that a belief is true if and only if it fits consistently and logically with a specified set of other beliefs within a larger system. Truth is determined by the internal consistency and logical interconnectedness of a system of beliefs.

3. Pragmatic theory of Truth:

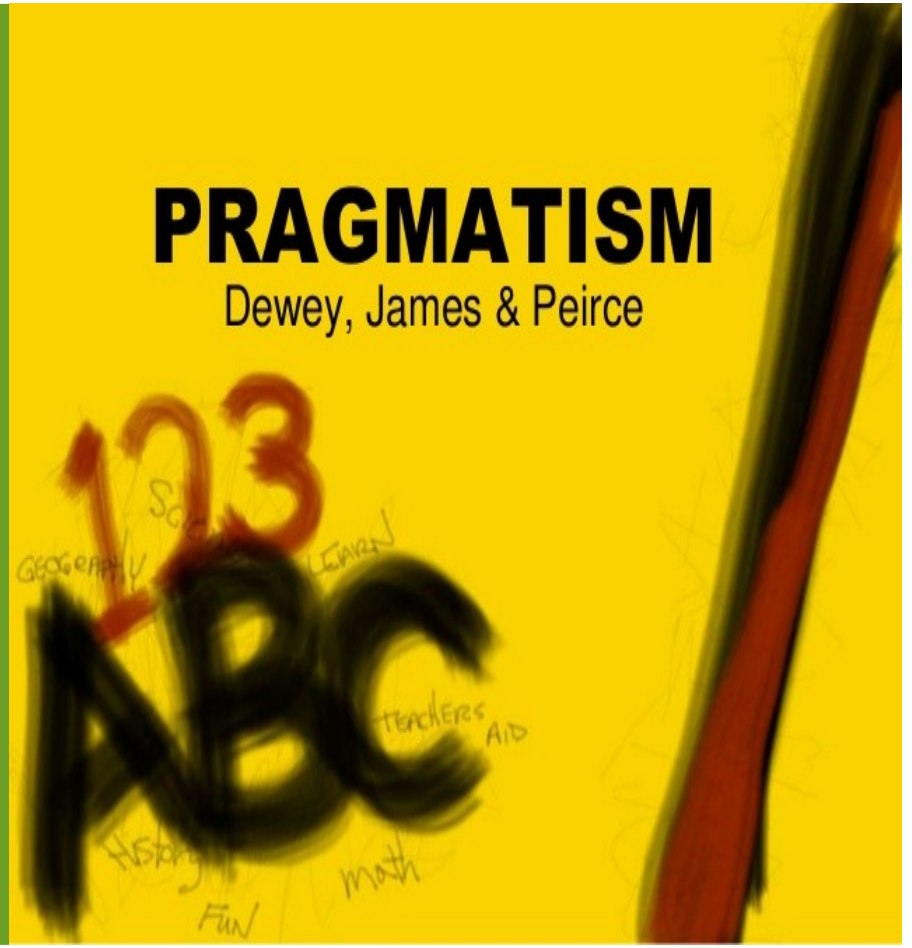
It defines truth in terms of its practical consequences, utility, or usefulness. A belief or statement is true if it "works" or leads to successful outcomes in practice.

Overview

- The word '**Pragma**'' derived from Greek word which means ***activity or work done.***
- Pragmatism is the practical approach to problems.
- Pragmatism believes that reality is constantly changing and that we learn best from applying our experiences and thoughts to problems.
- Pragmatism is as an epistemological framework offers practical approach to understanding truth and knowledge.
- ***Charles Sanders Peirce, William James, and John Dewey*** are three foundational figures in American pragmatism.
- **American pragmatism** believes that truth and the process of knowing are deeply related to experience and practical consequences.

Ideas for pragmatism

- Pragmatism means “act” related to consequences.
- It is a practical philosophy to solve daily life problems.
- Practical consequences are vital than meanings .
- Absolute knowledge is not possible.
- Adjust yourself with environment according to needs.
- Basis roots are change, reform and instrumentalism.
- Thinkers are William James, Pierce, Dewey.



William James (1842-1910)
"**Truth is what is workable or gives –Will to believe**



- Truth and values is defined in usefulness and work in practical experience.
- Logical method is used for problem solving and subjective individual experience is source of knowing.
- Believes must be based on practical need and requirements.
- Ideas of Psychology through the work of William James in "Will to believe."

Charles Sandre Pierce (1839-1914)
“Consider what effects things have”-Method of Inquiry



- Statement is true if it has some practical use.
- Knowing is grounded on science and logic and Thinking depend on signs and symbols.
- Beliefs are habit of action and truth can approach through investigation.
- The work of Logic by Pierce.

John Dewey (1859-1952)

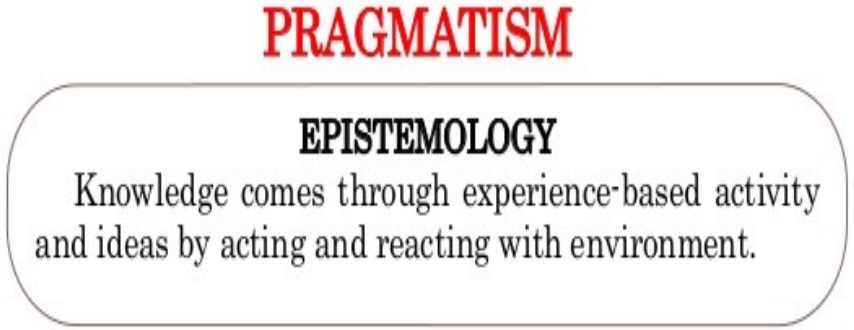
We only think when we are confronted with problems."



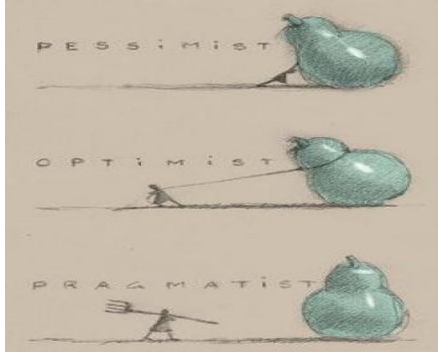
- Knowledge is acquired to control our life and environment and truth evolves as we adapt to changing conditions.
- Truth is what works in a specific context to resolve a difficulty.
- Knowing as an active process of interaction between humans and their environment.
- Ideas are instrumental to solve problem of life and must be tested by experiment.

Pragmatic Philosophy on Knowledge

1. Truth can be determined by its use and Knowledge is discovered according to its importance and its practical application.
2. Pragmatism argues that **truth is not an absolute** but is discovered and validated through **practical consequences, experience, and problem-solving**.
3. Knowledge arises from the interaction between the mind and environment, and its value is determined by how well it works in practice.



Reality is always in making progress.



- *Man is the measures of all things it means everything is relative so there is no absolute the truth.*
- *Ideas are true only when they solve real life problems so the truth is dependent on its workability.*
- *Ideas are true if they deal with practical experience so truth is known by its results.*



Knowledge is practical matter of approach to solve issu

- Absolute knowledge is impossible therefore get specific form of knowledge relate to your life.
- Problem solving and critical thinking is the key so used reasoning as method
- Knowledge is gained by doing or practical experience so emphasis on practical more.
- Ideas are defined by its use, unpractical ideas are to be rejected.
- Ideas could be concerned with present and immediate future.
- Ideas should be focused on individual growth and improve lifestyle.
- Man is supreme creation in the world so create its own value by himself.
- ***Ideas are determined by need of humankind.***

Summary
Pragmatism as a Dynamic Source of Truth

- In the light of Peirce, James, and Dewey, pragmatism offers a **flexible, experiential, and context-driven** account of epistemology.
- It rejects the notion of absolute, eternal truths and instead sees truth as:
  - **Knowledge is discovered through inquiry** (Peirce)
  - **Knowledge is validated by practical outcomes** (James)
  - **Knowledge is refined through experiential problem-solving** (Dewey)

Thus, pragmatism does not define knowledge in terms of static certainty but in terms of **continuous engagement, communal validation, and usefulness in life**.

Objections to Pragmatism

Philosophers have objected to pragmatism on numerous grounds.

Questions raises include:

- Does pragmatism have the resources for conceiving of disinterested intellectual and scientific inquiry?
- When pragmatism emphasizes that multiple realities exist because of the mind's capacity to have multiple interests?
- Does this imply that there is no reality apart from the mind?

EPISTEMOLOGY

Source of Knowing

SCIENTISM

- **Scientism** is the notion that natural science comprises the most authoritative worldview or form of human knowledge, and that it is superior to all other interpretations of life.



2.SCIENTISM

KNOLWEDGE COMES FROM SCIENTIFIC EXPERIMENT

Critical question

- Can we truly reduce human experience to scientific explanation?
- What are the effects of adopting scientism as an epistemological framework?
- In what areas might non-scientific methods of knowing be more appropriate?

2.SCIENTISM

- Scientific revolution begins with experiment of 100 species in laboratory by Aristotle.
- Copernicus changed the view of man to earth by experiment.
- Truths are justified by mathematical reason alone.
- Only tell those which is practically exist by verification.
- Faith in power of science to determine all truth and reality.

Overview : Scientism

- Scientism refers to the belief that **science is the only valid** source of knowledge and truth.
- Knowledge of reality is best or exclusively gained through the **natural sciences**.
- **Knowledge is mainly** emphasis on **empiricism** and **scientific methods**.
- **Scientism reject non-scientific ways of knowing** (e.g., intuition, religion, metaphysics).
- The idea emerge in 17th -18th century with the **rise of modern science**.
- **The key scientific Figures for scientism are** : **Isaac Newton**, **René Descartes**, **John Locke**.
- **Auguste Comte** argued that **science is the only valid way** of understanding reality which is known as **Positivism.**

Scientism in epistemology

- Scientism believe in empirical methods as the main source of path to truth.
- Science is viewed as the most reliable or even the only valid means of acquiring knowledge.



Criticism

- Scientism reduces complex human phenomena for e.g., emotions to mere **biological processes**.
- **Ignores philosophical questions** about the nature of knowledge itself e.g **limits of knowledge**.
- **Scientific knowledge** is viewed as the **only valid knowledge** is not true in dogmatism.
- **Science Cannot Answer All Questions**.
- Scientism faces limitations in addressing human experience, ethics, and meaning.
- **Ethical, moral, and metaphysical questions** are often beyond the reach of empirical science.

Summary

- **Empiricism** : Knowledge from observation and sensory experience.
- **Rationalism**: Knowledge through reason and logic independent of sensory data.
- **Scientism** : Knowledge can only be empirically tested in experiment.
- **Pragmatism**: Pragmatists argue that in ways of knowing experience and practical outcomes should also be considered.

Key features

- Knowledge comes from **empirical evidence** i-e what can be observed and be measured.
- Science provides the **most reliable and objective knowledge**.
- Emphasizes that only **scientific verification** counts as valid.
- There exists an **objective, mind-independent truth**,only **Scientific facts** describe the real world.

Conclusion

Scientism, as an epistemologically elevates science to the **primary means of obtaining knowledge** and understanding truth.

It emphasizes on **empirical evidence, logical verification, and scientific method** as the criteria for knowledge.

Further readings

For scientism

1. **"The Structure of Scientific Revolutions"** by **Thomas Kuhn**.
2. "The Science of Science and the Search for Truth" by **Paul Feyerabend**.
3. **Philosophy of Science: A Very Short Introduction"** by **Samir Okasha**.

For pragmatism

1. "**How to Make Our Ideas Clear"** (1878) by **Sandre Pierce.**
2. **A New Name for Some Old Ways of Thinking"** (1907) by **William James.**
3. "**Experience and Nature**" (1925) by **John Dewey.**

Activity

PRAGMATISM AND SCIENTISM

1

A key figure associated with the development of pragmatism is:

a) Immanuel Kant
b) John Locke
c) John Dewey
d) René Descartes

2

Who is considered to be a father of American pragmatism.

a) Charles S. Pierce
b) John Locke
c) John Dewey
d) William James

3

Pragmatism often views knowledge as:

a) A static collection of facts to be discovered.
b) A dynamic process of inquiry and experimentation.
c) Inherently subjective and unknowable.
d) Primarily concerned with aesthetic appreciation.

4

Scientism is the belief that:

a) Mind is only valid ways of knowing.
b) Scientific methods are the only reliable sources of knowledge.
c) Scientific progress is inherently beneficial to society.
d) All human knowledge can be explained through artistic expression.

5

If someone argues that moral values, aesthetic judgments, and spiritual experiences are meaningless because they cannot be empirically tested is likely towards:

a) Empiricism
b) Rationalism
c) Scientism
d) Pragmatism